and classroom realities. Another AI project, a teaching coach, is being tested in Jhansi that gives timely and personalised feedback to teachers about classroom instruction; it is aimed at complementing existing training and support structures. IIT Bombay has developed an app called TARA that identifies early oral reading challenges through AI-assisted assessments; this can be particularly helpful in primary grades. Rajasthan has sped up analysis of learning data, at scale, using OCR-enabled assessments to evaluate student responses from paper-based tests.

Globally, some examples that stand out include a WhatsApp-based tutor in Ghana that has achieved learning gains of 0.36 standard deviations in mathematics by providing just one additional hour of instruction per week—a meaningful result in systems constrained by large class sizes and limited access to tutoring. In Kenya, AI-driven reading and math assessments have reduced the time teachers spend assessing each child from over 13 minutes to under two minutes, and they enable targeted instruction for different learning levels.

But the quality of these tools in education, despite rapid experimentation, remains uneven and poorly understood. While hundreds of products are being used, fewer than two dozen have published studies on quality or impact. Scale is often driven by excitement over novelty and convenience rather than evidence. Without clear guardrails, there is a real risk that AI adoption will deepen existing learning divides.

Where evidence does exist, it shows that when thoughtfully designed and integrated, AI can contribute to learning gains—whether through improved outcomes from AI-enabled tutoring or efficiency gains from AI-integrated assessments. These early signals highlight both AI's potential and the importance of being intentional and deliberate about how it is designed and deployed.

TAKEAWAYS

- **The real question is not if AI will enter Indian education, but how it will be integrated equitably and improve teaching and learning outcomes**
- **The quality of hundreds of tools remains uneven. Many states have pilot projects but fewer than two dozen AI projects globally have studies on impact**
- **India's policy response, which already has a Centre of Excellence in Artificial Intelligence for Education in the works, is critical at a moment like this**

Hence, India's policy response at this moment is critical. The central government's plan to establish a Centre of Excellence in Artificial Intelligence for Education, backed by an allocation of Rs 500 crore, is an important step toward building the foundations for meaningful AI use. By focusing on contextual datasets and models, the initiative recognises that AI for Indian education must be built for Indian classrooms. Initiatives such as the CSF-backed EdTech Tulna are working to define standards so that governments and other buyers can make informed choices apropos AI tools. Though still in the early stages of development, such efforts will steer the market.

A TEACHING COACH IN JHANSI, READING ASSESSOR IN MUMBAI AND OCR-ANALYSER IN RAJASTHAN ARE ONLY SOME AI TOOLS BEING TESTED IN INDIA. SUCCESS WILL **DEPEND ON USER FLUENCY**

AI's success in education will ultimately depend on how students, teachers and parents use it, particularly given widespread concerns about plagiarism being made easier and foundational skills like writing and problem-solving being made weaker. These concerns resonate strongly in high-stakes education systems like India's. When learning relies heavily on predictable answers and memorisation, powerful tools—human or artificial—can be misused. The response, therefore, cannot be limited to policing or detection. The tools must be designed in ways that support thinking and don't replace it. Students and teachers need sound judgement to distinguish between use cases for AI and independent reasoning. Initiatives such as the CSF-backed AI Samarth are being adopted by public schools in eight states and aim to equip millions of users with literacy in this new technology. Paramount is a focus on critical, safe and responsible use.

As we look ahead to 2026, chatbots will increasingly sit alongside chalkboards. Whether it becomes a force for inclusion or driver of new divides will depend on the decisions made today. ■

Ashish Dhawan is Founder and Chairperson, Central Square Foundation, and Gouri Gupta is Senior Director, EdTech and AI